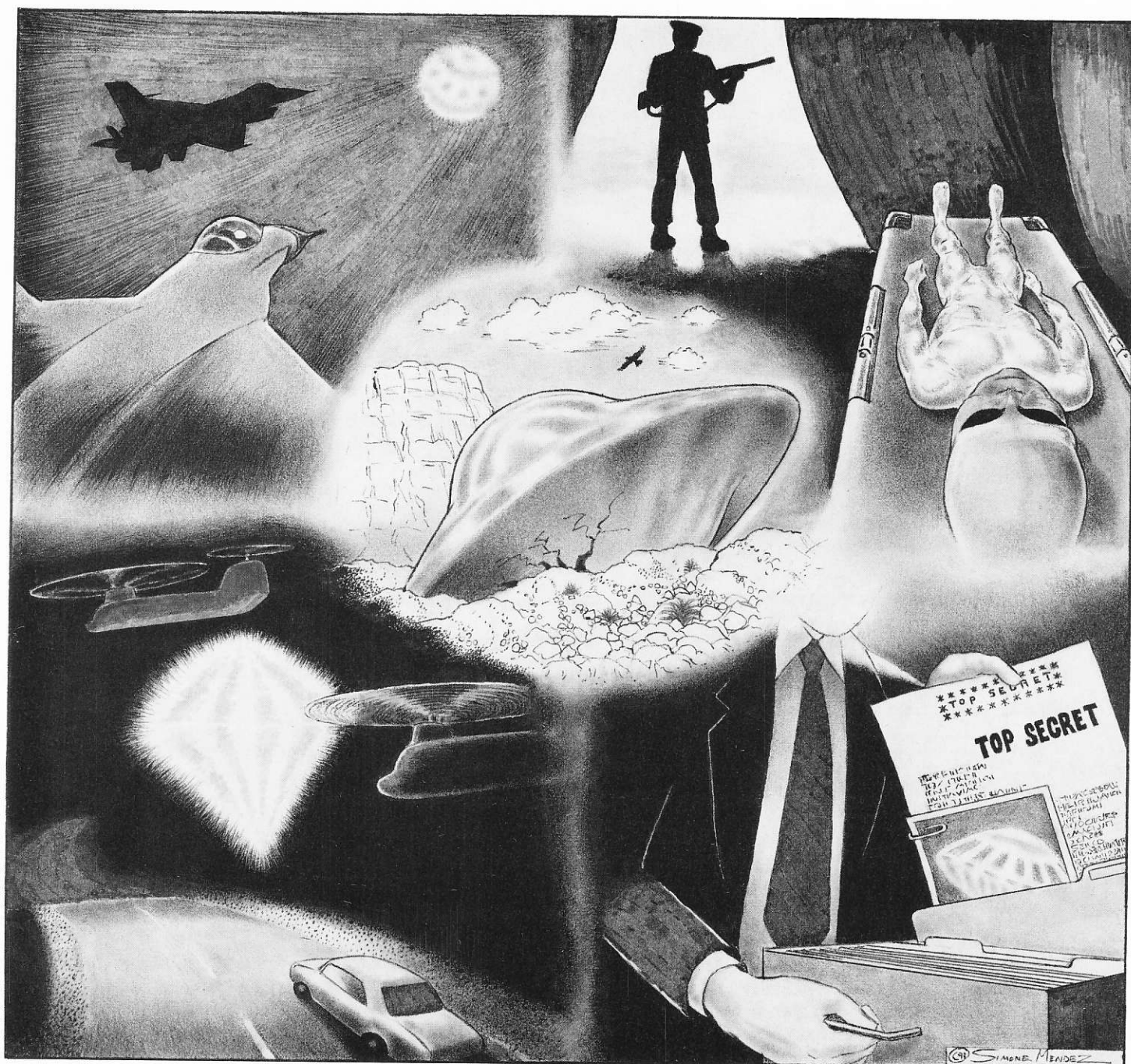


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International UFO Reporter

September/October 1991

Volume 16, Number 5



Concealing the ultimate secret

INTERNATIONAL UFO REPORTER

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It is the persistence of the UFO reports, and the contents of those reports, that constitute the UFO phenomenon; it is this phenomenon that must be studied and its validity judged independently of any hypothesis of its origin. To do otherwise is simply not honest science.

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Address all editorial correspondence to *International UFO Reporter*, Jerome Clark, editor, 612 North Oscar Avenue, Canby, Minnesota 56220.

Address all subscription correspondence to *International UFO Reporter*, 2457 West Peterson Avenue, Chicago, Illinois 60659.

The *International UFO Reporter* is a benefit publication mailed to Associates of the Center for a contribution of \$25.00 or more. Foreign Associates add \$5.00 for delivery. All amounts in U.S. funds. Other publications also available for contributors of larger amounts. For details, write to the J. Allen Hynek Center for UFO Studies, 2457 West Peterson Avenue, Chicago, Illinois 60659, USA. **Postmaster:** Send Form 3579 to CUFOS, 2457 West Peterson Avenue, Chicago, Illinois 60659.

Somebody must be behind it

On September 7 and 8, at a conference in Sydney, Australia, I delivered a two-part lecture which dealt in part with conspiracy theories in historical and current ufology. After the first lecture a woman approached me to say that she would have to listen to the second before deciding whether or not I am a CIA agent. In the middle of that final lecture, as I was making light of Milton William Cooper's leave-your-brains-at-the-door-and-believe yarns about a secret government and its alliance with malevolent extraterrestrials, a man in the audience began shouting and demanding that I shut up.

Another lecturer, our old friend Bill Chalker, was asked during the question-and-answer session if it was true that he works for the CIA. I thought this was pretty funny, but Chalker was not amused. He told me later that the charge was being made, indeed had even been published, by Australia's Cooperists; what concerned him was the possibility that witnesses in future UFO cases might hear of it and refuse to speak with him—certainly a legitimate concern.

Conspiracy delirium has afflicted Australia, though the illness seems to have been contracted by exposure, I am sorry to say, to my own country. It's not just that the writings of Cooper and John Lear circulate widely within the New Age community, but an expatriate American who claims to be an "escapee from the CIA" (as someone described him to me) feeds the paranoia with his own stories, for which as always no supporting evidence is forthcoming. In our time it is secret documents one has seen, rather than Space Brothers one has met, that comprise the stuff of fantasies and hoaxes.

Not, of course, that conspiracy obsessions are ufodom's alone. Not by a long shot. As a news junkie I wake up every morning and switch on cable television's C-Span, which hosts a show on which politicians, officials, pundits, and journalists take calls from viewers. The subject, of course, is never UFOs, but on some days as many as one caller in three seems to subscribe to some variety of conspiracy theory. Now that Communism, happily, is fading from the world scene and so, incidentally, from a leading role in conspiratorial scenarios, the principal suspects have become the CIA (the focus of all evil in the solar system, as we all know), "the media" (believed to be a monolithic entity with, in one caller's



Jerome Clark

words, a "definite agenda"—which is to promote the interests of, depending on who's on the phone, the right or the left end of the political spectrum), and the Israelis (or, as some callers unsightly express it, thereby tipping us off to their real views, "the Jews").

I happened to remark on the peculiar proliferation of conspiracy beliefs in a conversation with Barry Williams and Tim Mendham, two genial representatives of Australian Skeptics, down under's equivalent of CSICOP. Affecting a darkly conspiratorial expression, Mendham declared, "Somebody must be behind it!"

Mendham's wisecrack came back to me as I was reading Jacques Vallee's new *Revelations: Alien Contact and Human Deception* (Ballantine Books), the ultimate conspiracy book. Vallee's thesis can be summed up thus: Conspirators are inventing conspiracy theories to mask the *real* conspiracy.

Revelations is a sequel to Vallee's 1979 book *Messengers of Deception*, which proposed that a shadowy group of intelligence operatives is manipulating UFO beliefs and creating phony UFO encounters in an effort to direct societal consciousness. An early, less elaborate version of this notion was circulated in the 1950s and 1960s by a former government scientist, Leon Davidson. Davidson thought that CIA psychological-warfare specialists posing as space people had fooled George Adamski and other contactees. In *Messengers* Vallee advances essentially the same idea, though without crediting Davidson; also, unlike Davidson, he believes that a real UFO phenomenon, supernatural, perhaps unknowable, but certainly not extraterrestrial, exists beyond the manipulation.

In common with his other works of the last two decades, *Revelations* is an interesting book even if it is not a good one. Vallee is no profound thinker, but no one would deny that he is a first-rate storyteller. Anyone who enjoys tales from the fringes—and who doesn't?—will have great fun with the chapters on UMMO and on Franck Fontaine's bogus abduction. Vallee's deadpan account of his dinner with Bill Cooper is hilarious. And he shows admirable good sense when he takes after

continued on page 21

Hiding the hardware

by Bruce Maccabee

■ ■ **Bruce Maccabee, Ph.D., an optical physicist who works for the U.S. Navy, is chairman of the Fund for UFO Research. This is a revised version of a paper given at a November 1990 conference sponsored by CUFOS and the Santa Barbara Centre for Humanistic Studies.**

U p until about 10 years ago, if you suggested that some small group of individuals within the U.S. government had convincing evidence of UFO reality, you would be accused of engaging in conjecture based on unsupported statements by persons who claimed, though they could not prove it, to have inside knowledge. Then in 1978, when Stanton Friedman and William L. Moore began to interview witnesses and informants in the Roswell incident, the first real evidence began to emerge that some officials not only knew that UFOs are real but actually had one. The evidence that came out of the Roswell investigation also indicated that top government and military people created a plan to conceal the evidence from the public and even from most of officialdom. Continued investigation of the Roswell evident by Kevin Randle, Don Schmitt, and others has strengthened the story.

I could simply cite the Roswell research as reason for my belief that the government knew all along. I have decided to leave the Roswell crash out of this discussion, however, and concentrate on other, less well known evidence relating to the question of official UFO knowledge.

But how *could* the government have known all along? A comprehensive history of the subject to the end of 1973, David M. Jacobs' *The UFO Controversy in America* (1975), found no clear evidence that the government had secret information. Instead, the history seemed to show a sort of bumbling approach to the subject by the Air Force during Projects Sign (1948), Grudge (1949-1952), and Blue Book (1952-1969) and even by the independent Condon study at the University of Colorado (1967-1968). Though these various projects left numerous sightings unexplained, they stated plainly that there was no reason to believe UFOs represent a nonhuman intelligence and technology.

In the five years following the publication of Jacobs' book, much more information on government activities

became available. In 1975 the records of Project Blue Book (including Sign and Grudge) and the Air Force Office of Special Investigations (AFOSI) were released. During the next three years UFO researchers used the Freedom of Information and Privacy Act to obtain thousands of pages of documents from the FBI, CIA, and other government agencies. All of these documents and the Blue Book files were thoroughly reviewed for any indication that the government had hard evidence or that it was withholding information about continuing UFO research. The result of all this work was much smoke but no smoking gun—in other words, no direct evidence of a government cover-up or, as Friedman would say, a Cosmic Watergate.

A new history

By 1980 the history of government involvement with UFO sightings, as documented by official records, seemed to be this:

Well over 10,000 sightings had been processed through channels. Many of these had been investigated in some way, and about 1000 remained unexplained; this figure incorporates the unexplained cases in FBI, CIA, and other files with the Blue Book unknowns. Some of these cases were multiple-witness daylight sightings in which no conventional explanation seems possible. In discussing one such case in a then-classified article in the CIA's house organ *Studies in Intelligence* (Fall 1966), Maj. Hector Quintanilla, Blue Book's last director, admitted that the sighting defied explanation; he was referring to the Socorro, New Mexico, CE3 of April 24, 1964. Yet the public posture of the Air Force was that UFO sightings represented nothing new in the way of technology and that each sighting, even the most difficult ones, would eventually fall to mundane accounting if enough information were available.

Thus by 1980 the conventional history provided little direct support for the view that the Air Force really did not ignore unexplained sightings, as Blue Book would have had us believe, but rather did try to study them. The Roswell revelations and other information obtained since 1980, however, force us to go back over the early history of the subject to find out what was missed before and to revise accordingly—in other words, to write a new history of UFOs in America.

Rumors and anecdotes whispered among UFO enthusiasts comprised the evidence of an official cover-up before the 1980s. Frank Scully's book about crashed discs, *Behind the Flying Saucers* (1950), had been discredited years before, and sober ufologists had little time for similar stories. Few held the view that the government possessed hard evidence. As I have said, the thousands of pages of documents, mostly at the Secret classification level or lower, released in the 1970s proved that the government had anything truly startling. Yet at the same time all of this documentation was coming out essentially in support of the government claim to have no proof, the first documentary evidence showing up the falseness of this claim emerged.

Wilbert Brockhouse Smith was a senior radio engineer who worked on secret defense projects for Canada's Department of Transport. Having seen a UFO himself, he had an interest in the subject. While in Washington, D.C., in the fall of 1950, he decided to try to find out what the U.S. government was doing about flying-saucer sightings. There had also been sightings in Canada, so the Canadian defense authorities had also become at least mildly interested. Smith made "discreet inquiries through the Canadian Embassy staff in Washington" and learned the following: Flying saucers are the most highly classified subject in the U.S. government; they exist; a special project under Vannevar Bush is studying them, and the subject is considered of tremendous importance. Smith included this information in a Top Secret memorandum written on November 21, 1950. This has become known as the Smith memorandum.

Several years after the Canadian government released it in 1979, Friedman located the source of Smith's information, Robert Sarbacher. Dr. Sarbacher, in a letter to researcher William S. Steinman in 1983, said he recalled being contacted by Dr. Brenner of the Canadian embassy, though he couldn't remember all of what he had said at the time. (Brenner was Smith's contact at the embassy.) Sarbacher said he learned of the remains of a flying saucer and alien bodies while he was working in Washington for the government on classified projects in the years following World War II. In a 1985 interview he told me he was invited to travel to Wright-Patterson Air Force Base to view the remains of a crashed UFO but was unable to go at the time. Several of his acquaintances—names not recalled 30 years later—did go and subsequently told him, among other things, that "certain materials reported to have come from flying saucer crashes were extremely light and tough." He also recalled that the "instruments or people operating these machines were also of very light weight, sufficient to withstand the tremendous deceleration and acceleration associated with their machinery." Sarbacher told me that "the 'people' who operated those things were built different than we. They seemed to have no inertia. They seemed to be like insects. Maybe they were robots."

Sarbacher had numerous credits and accomplish-

ments, as can be seen in his biography in *Who's Who in America*. He was an expert in missile guidance. In the late 1940s he was a member of the Research and Development Board, a group of scientists who consulted for the military. This could explain why he was invited to view the wreckage of a crashed saucer. He repeated his story, without variations, to a number of researchers before he died in 1986. It is worth noting that a 1947 teletype message found (in 1977) in the FBI "Flying Disc" file states that the Roswell wreckage was being flown to Wright Field (later Wright-Patterson AFB) for analysis. Presumably this was the material to which Sarbacher referred; certainly his description of it is the same as that of Roswell eyewitnesses.

The paper cover

A document written about three years before the Smith memorandum also hints that top government and military people knew flying saucers are real. This document gives an overview of the flying-saucer situation as it was understood by an apparently middle-level Army Air Force officer (name and rank unknown) during late July or August 1947. This document was found not in Air Force files but in FBI files. (In articles in the *MUFON UFO Journal* in 1977 and 1978, I have pointed out the value of the FBI files in providing a window on Air Force activities in the early years.) This document says that after reviewing several dozen of the most credible reports to come to the (Army) Air Force, the conclusion is that "this flying saucer situation is not all imaginary or seeing too much in some natural phenomenon." It further states that the objects appear to be "metallic," that whenever a trail was observed it was like a rocket exhaust, that the shape was generally circular, elliptical, or disc-shaped, flat on the bottom and domed on top, that there were groups flying in formation, and that they often oscillated laterally while flying.

These statements indicate that some Air Force officers had concluded that flying saucers are real during the summer of 1947. (These statements were echoed, almost to the word, several months later by Gen. Nathan F. Twining in a letter to be discussed.) Of particular interest to this discussion is this enigmatic statement (emphasis added): "Lack of topside inquiries, when compared to the prompt and demanding enquiries that have originated topside upon former events, *give more than ordinary weight to the possibility that this is a project about which the President, etc. know.*"

In other words, from the writer's perspective, in comparison with previous instances—for example, the discovery of Japanese barrage balloons intended to bomb the American mainland—there was a seeming lack of interest from the higher-ups in the military as if they already knew what was going on and needed no more information. (On the other hand, in the conventional history, as portrayed in his *The Report on Unidentified*

Flying Objects [1956], Capt. Edward J. Ruppelt wrote, "The brass wanted an answer quickly and people were taking off in all directions.")

Unfortunately the history of the UFO subject during the summer of 1947 is incomplete. The part of the history involving the retrieval of material from the desert near Roswell is now known reasonably well, though there are still some holes in the history. But the available information seems to be confined to the period between the initial discovery of the crash debris and the shipment of the material to Wright Field, a period of less than a week. What happened to it after it reached Wright Field is not yet known.

What is known is that flying saucers were discussed at the highest levels of government. We also know, thanks to the FBI file, that Gen. George Schulgen, the head of the Intelligence Requirements Branch of Air Force Intelligence, discussed the saucer situation with an FBI agent on July 10, 1947. He portrayed the situation as serious and demanding close attention. He asked for FBI help in interviewing witnesses, ostensibly to determine whether or not Russian subversion could be involved. (FBI director J. Edgar Hoover authorized investigations for several months and then, after finding no evidence of subversion, withdrew the authorization. Nevertheless the FBI continued to collect UFO information for years afterwards.)

There is scant evidence of what the top military and government people were thinking and doing about flying saucers during July and August 1947. From the public point of view, after the June-July flap was over and stories more or less dropped out of the press, the subject was forgotten. Air Force Intelligence knew, though, that the sightings continued but at a lower rate.

The next undisputed documentary evidence of high-level involvement comes in a September 23, 1947, letter from Lt. Gen. Twining of the Air Materiel Command (AMC) to Gen. Schulgen. In this letter Twining reported that he conferred with scientists from several laboratories at Wright Field to gain an opinion "as requested by AC/AS-2" (i.e., Schulgen) as to the "flying discs." Twining wrote that the opinion was "based on interrogation report data furnished by AC/AS-2 and preliminary studies" by personnel of several aircraft laboratories. Twining said that at a joint conference these scientists and engineers concluded that (1) the saucers are "something real and not visionary or fictitious," (2) they appear to be disc-shaped and of appreciable size, (3) they perform maneuvers, and (4) they appear to be metallic. The letter essentially repeats the conclusions presented in the unsigned, undated analysis I referred to earlier.

It also recommends setting up a classified project to collect data which could then be supplied to the armed forces, the Atomic Energy Commission, the Joint Research and Development Board (of which Sarbacher was a member a year later), the Air Force Scientific Advisory Group, the National Advisory Committee on

Aeronautics (NACA, the predecessor of NASA), the RAND (Research and Development) Project, and the Nuclear Energy for Propulsion of Aircraft (NEPA) Project. These were all top-level, classified projects involving the best government scientists. Twining's suggestion that all of these organizations should be involved indicates how serious he thought the saucer problem was—very serious.

In the letter Twining has placed a statement which supports the government's "no proof" stance. There is, he writes, a "lack of physical evidence . . . which would undeniably prove the existence of these objects." He also said that there was a possibility that the discs "are of domestic origin" from a project "not known to AC/AS-2 or this command [AMC]." This second statement indicates that Twining acknowledged the possibility of information of which he was unaware (for which, in other words, he had no need to know). Yet it certainly seems likely that he would have known if the Roswell material had been shipped to Wright. Could it be that Twining *lied* in this Secret-level letter so as to keep those with only Secret clearances from learning of the hard evidence?

Yes, that is possible. Perhaps the people who worked for Schulgen and who would formulate the intelligence-collection requirements based on Twining's September 23 letter did not need to know that hardware existed. All they need to know was that their boss (Schulgen) wanted to gather as much information as possible about flying discs.

It is important here to consider something that is not obvious: that the possession of a crashed UFO and bodies is not enough. The hardware proves only that UFOs are real. It does not provide information about what the UFOs are doing, how they interact with our environment, how they interact with people and human technology, and so on. Thus a collection program would be needed to provide this sort of information to supplement the information derived from the hardware. If a collection program were to be set up while, at the same time, the knowledge of the existence of hardware were to be carefully concealed, then it would be necessary to make no positive references to hardware in any communications regarding the collection project. The top people might even decide to include negative, deceptive information or disinformation to be sure that the persons involved in the collection project never realized there was hardware.

Schulgen's response to Twining's letter was discovered by Bill Moore and Jaime Shandera in formerly classified Air Force Intelligence files which were released to the National Archives and finally declassified in 1985. Schulgen's response, dated October 30, 1947, consisted of a cover letter, a draft of the intelligence-requirements document "on Flying Saucer type aircraft," and a final version of the document. This document was sent to military-intelligence operatives throughout the world to tell them what sorts of information they should collect

and what sorts of flying craft they should try to spy on. The cover letter to the list of collection requirements says that sightings have been made at many places around the world by many competent observers, including U.S. Air Force officers. The cover letter lists some of the more obvious visual characteristics, gives an overview of the history of sightings, and then says (emphasis added), "For the purpose of analysis and evaluation of these so-called 'flying saucers' the object sighted is assumed to be a manned craft of unknown origin. While there remains the possibility of Russian manufacture, based on the perspective thinking and actual accomplishments of the Germans, it is [the] considered opinion of some elements that the object may in fact represent an *interplanetary craft of some kind*."

Though this document emphasizes collecting information related to flying-disc and wing craft based on the Horton brothers' research in Germany and refers generally to advances in conventional aircraft theory and construction, there are a few decidedly unconventional requests in the draft version; these requests, curiously, were left out of the final version. Intelligence operatives were to report any craft which was constructed in part by unconventional materials using "unusual fabrication methods to achieve extreme light weight and structural stability." One of the unconventional materials listed was "balsa wood or similar material." (Maj. Jesse Marcel, in describing the rigid rods found in the Roswell material, said they were light weight like balsa wood.) Intelligence operatives were also asked to report any aircraft in which the "presence of an unconventional or unusual type of propulsion system cannot be ruled out and should be considered of great interest." For example (emphasis added), "the power plant would likely be an integral part of the aircraft and could possibly *not be distinguished as an item separate from the aircraft*."

Now, where would the writer of the intelligence-collection requirements get the idea that there could be any military aircraft built of material similar to balsa wood or that there could be an aircraft in which the power plant was indistinguishable from the aircraft itself? Certainly no American developments, or any extrapolation of German research, led in that direction.

I suggest that these intelligence-collection requirements were built into the document because Schulgen knew of the extremely bizarre characteristics of the Roswell disc and wanted to be sure that in the event an intelligence operative should come across a craft with such characteristics, the operative would recognize that it was something to report. I suggest that these characteristics were removed from the final version because Schulgen felt they were too much like clues that an actual flying saucer was available for analysis. How else, after all, would one know about construction materials or power-plant design—or a nonexistent power plant?

Two months later, on December 31, Maj. Gen. L. C. Craigie, the Air Force Chief of Staff, established Project

Sign in response to Twining's suggestion. Operated at the Restricted clearance level, Sign was given a high priority for receiving information from Air Force Intelligence. Half a year later, in the summer of 1948, according to Ruppelt, the Sign analysts, using testimonial data and photographs only, concluded that flying saucers were real and interplanetary. Ruppelt wrote that the Sign report was an intelligence document described as an "estimate of the situation." Such a report is not intended to be the final word on whatever subject it is written about but is rather just what it says: an "estimate" of what is going on. Ruppelt got his information from old-timers at the Air Technical Intelligence Center (ATIC) at Wright-Patterson. He was told that the estimate was reviewed by higher authorities and finally wound up on the desk of Gen. Hoyt S. Vandenberg, who had replaced Craigie as Chief of Staff. Vandenberg reportedly said he could not accept such an extraordinary conclusion without better evidence and returned the estimate to its writers. It was then rewritten to remove the extraterrestrial conclusion, according to Ruppelt, and then was supposed to be destroyed. A few copies survived, however, and Ruppelt read one of them. The rewritten version has been rediscovered, as I shall discuss later.

The failure of the estimate to discuss hardware may lead one to conclude that the Air Force had no hardware. But this conclusion comes out of a false premise: that Sign personnel would necessarily have known or had access to existing hardware. Since Craigie's letter had directed Sign to operate at the lowly Restricted level, its people could not receive more highly classified—Top Secret—material. Apparently the top brass had decided that the Sign people had no need to know about hardware. Because they would not have known, they could not have mentioned it in the estimate even though it was itself classified Top Secret.

Son of the estimate

In 1985 the Air Intelligence Report No. 100-203-79, dated December 10, 1948, was discovered in formerly classified Top Secret Air Force Intelligence files released by the National Archives. The title of the document is "Analysis of Flying Object Incidents in the U.S." I have dubbed this report the "son of the estimate" because it appears to be what Ruppelt described as the rewritten estimate; it does not refer to the extraterrestrial hypothesis.

Though we have no proof that Ruppelt actually saw this particular document, we do know that Maj. Dewey J. Fournet, Jr. who worked with Ruppelt, did read it in 1952 because he signed for it. (Persons accessing Top Secret documents must sign a paper indicating that they have it.) The complete version of this document was made into an official Air Force Intelligence report written by ATIC in conjunction with the Office of Naval Intelligence. This document presents strong testimonial

evidence that flying saucers are real. It also speculates that they might be a Soviet development based on German World War II research. But one gains the impression from the document that the writers did not hold out much hope for the Soviet-development hypothesis.

That the Sign operatives were unaware of the Roswell material is unsurprising. In the rarified world of Top Secret classification all information is divided into compartments with need-to-know access requirements. One's boss must provide justification (need-to-know) for a person to work on a particular compartmented subject. The Sign analysts could do their job of collecting and analyzing visual sightings and testimonial evidence about flying saucers without knowing that hardware existed.

Gen. Vandenberg, on the other hand, certainly would have had a need-to-know for material related to any crashed objects, and it is assumed that he was aware of the Roswell material. Why, then, would he reject the estimate's extraterrestrial conclusion, if he knew full well (or at any rate strongly suspected) that it was correct?

To answer this question, consider what would have been the result if he *had* accepted the conclusion. Immediately many more people, including everyone with access to the estimate, would know that saucers were real. Such an official conclusion might create many spies within the organization, well-intentioned persons who were looking for further evidence and who might stumble onto information about the hardware. Moreover, it is likely that such an important conclusion would leak out and destroy the Air Force attempt to withhold information about the subject from the American people. Thus, to stop the spread of information about UFO reality, Vandenberg had to reject the estimate's conclusion.

Four decades of testimony

Over the past four decades there has been no shortage of unsupported testimony concerning a government UFO cover-up of hardware, bodies, and other significant evidence. Some of this testimony has been recorded in books and articles. Leonard H. Stringfield has published a number of such stories. In his 1983 book *UFO Dynamics* Berthold Eric Schwarz published intriguing testimony from a former Air Force officer.

Many years ago the late Isabel Davis, who was a hard-nosed, skeptical ufologist not easily taken in by tall tales, told me that an acquaintance of hers back in the late 1950s, a medical doctor and physiologist, claimed to have analyzed strange nonhuman body parts at a highly secure facility. The doctor said she had been taken to the facility where she was virtually stripped and given special clothing. Inside she found all the instrumentation she needed, and she found herself studying portions of anthropoid bodies which she immediately recognized as coming from no known species. After completing her work, she wrote her conclusions in a notebook. She took

nothing with her as she left through the special doors. Her clothes were returned, and she went back to her normal life with the admonishment that she should not speak about her experience. As she pointed out to Davis, however, the admonition was unnecessary because her story was bizarre and unbelievable and she had no proof it had ever happened.

What follows is the testimony of a former lieutenant colonel in the Air Force. At the time of the event he was the weather officer at the headquarters of the Fifth Air Force near Tokyo:

"I arrived in October 1957. I was told at the time that there were four F-106s stationed in the vicinity, two in Okinawa and two in Masawa [islands off the Japanese mainland]. I was told that these were especially instrumented 106s, and I thought that was strange because 106s were just being introduced in the States. [The first test flight was in December 1956, and they were ordered in April 1957. The first squadron was organized in the spring of 1959.] I didn't learn any more about these special 106s.

"More than a year later, in the spring of 1959, I was in the combat-operations (radar-control) center, and it was early evening, just at dusk. I was giving the weather forecast, as I always did, because I was the staff weather officer to the combat-operation center. While I was there, one of the guys invited me to see how the operations center worked. We were standing there and talking when all of a sudden all hell broke loose. Everyone got excited, and one of the guys blurted out, 'They're back again.' I asked the guy who was escorting me through the facility, 'What is back again?' I assumed he would answer because I gave briefings there all the time. They were plotting the aircraft, and they had plotted something, just south of Masawa, up between Honshu and Hokkaido, but on the Pacific Ocean side.

"The guy I was with said, 'There is an unidentified flying object here.' And I said something like, 'Well, tell me why that's so important.' He replied, 'We've seen them quite frequently, and they travel at some 2000 mph. For some strange reason it frequently happens that one of them will stop in this position and hover.' And the radar people were plotting the object as being stationary. The guy I was with said that they would stay there for anywhere from half an hour to several hours, maybe even three hours, and then they proceed [westward between the two islands—over the strait between the north and south main islands of Japan], and then they disappear off the scope so you can't track them.

"Then I heard someone say, 'Shall we scramble them?' and I asked the guy, 'What are they talking about?' He replied, 'The two special 106s which have been especially instrumented to track and fire on these objects.' At that point the commander in the center ordered the planes to scramble. I asked if it looked as if the object would stay there, and the guy said it was behaving as it had done in the past, so they will scramble.

"After the scramble order went out, the word came back that one of the 106s couldn't get fully functional. He was having difficulty, and his instrumentations weren't full up, and the operations commander said, 'Damn. There it goes again. We've had this every time we've tried to scramble.' And then the other pilot says, 'I'm functionally okay. Got two navigation aides out, but everything else seems okay. My special sensor is operating.' So the commander says, 'Go ahead and launch.' And the other guy couldn't get launched, and so they said, 'Shall we proceed with just one?' There was some hemming and hawing for about a minute or less, and the commander said, 'Go ahead,' and they asked me for a weather forecast.

"I said there were some low clouds and then a middle layer of cloud in there, oh, I forget, about 15,000 [feet] or something like that, but it was clear above with just light stratus and a full moon. The commander said, 'Yeah, then he won't have any trouble tracking.'

"And so the pilot climbed on out and said he was clear on top. And then there were a few minutes or so, maybe eight or 10 minutes, and then he says he got it in sight. Because there was a general interest in the commander center in what was happening, they put it on a speaker system. I could hear the down link from the pilot. The radar-scope operators had a tie in with the Masawa operators on the radars, and they were the only ones who could hear the ground link up, so I heard only half of the conversation. Basically they were vectoring him in, and he said something like 'I've got it in sight,' and he described what appeared to be a circular object that was hovering. It was metallic and had a cockpit on top. So I thought, gee, that's pretty interesting. And he said it was a UFO, and he had it in sight, and he asked if he should make a firing pass. And then the discussion was that they would have to get authority for that.

"Now, I worked over there for two or three years, and I was in typhoon forecasting. It was high priority. And if you ever tried to get single sideband in those days—that was the latest advance in communications—it was still difficult to get communications back. [Single sideband refers to a special mode of radio transmission.] They got a communication link in less than five minutes!

"And so they called the Pentagon to get authority, and the word came back, yes, make a firing pass. Okay, so the pilot said, 'Will roll in,' and he rolled in [in other words, went into an attack pattern], and he fired them [missiles] off. And then all of a sudden his voice went into a high falsetto. [This suggests that the pilot was terrified, fearing for his life but controlling his fear so that he could still operate the aircraft.] It was real strange. He blurted out that he fired, and they [missiles] had detonated but did not hit it. They detonated just at the edge of it, like a shield, he said, like an invisible shield. But he said it looked as if none of the shrapnel or anything penetrated through.

"And then he says, 'They've turned on some kind of

beam, and they're turning,' and he says, 'They're coming after me.' And then he went into a vertical diving maneuver. And then the radar operators started screaming out that it was moving and vectoring toward him, and they started counting out the ranges as it was coming down. The pilot was just breathing heavily and obviously under great stress but controlled, and he said, 'It's moving closer.' And he just kept describing how it kept gaining on him, and this beam was coming towards him.

"And then the radar operators said, 'Contact.' The two blips matched! And a radar operator said, 'My God, there's no separation,' and then he says, 'The thing has stopped. It's just a single blip hovering, but there's nothing else.' [Subsequently this blip also disappeared.]

"And what happened was that for four days after that I gave weather briefings every day for a search up there. They never did find anything."

During other discussions this officer indicated that at this time of his life he had little knowledge of and no interest in UFOs. It was not until years later that the implications of what had happened became apparent to him. This is how he expressed his feelings about the event:

"At that time I did not take it for much of anything. I just thought that it was some kind of [Soviet] experimental aircraft . . . because I couldn't have cared less [about UFOs]. But as I reflected back, several things came out of this. The first is that they [the USAF] knew what they were after. The second is that the Air Force denies that they ever had an aircraft shot down. The third is that they denied they ever tried to shoot one [UFO] down. And it also says those planes were in position for a year and a half before the incident took place. So they knew they had something up there all that time. And the guy who was with me when it happened said that they [the UFOs] routinely set up. For some reason there was a regular pattern established by them. [They often flew southward from northeast of Japan, stopped nearly over the Straits of Japan, hovered, and then flew westward.] And that's why we positioned those aircraft up there."

This Air Force man had other interesting stories to tell, including one about a former friend who was also an Air Force officer and who became a member of what his friend called the "real" Project Blue Book. This "real" Blue Book was not the publicly known project.

MJ-12 by any other name

Perhaps now is the time to address the issue of the controversial Eisenhower briefing document (EBD). This document—which, if true, would by itself blow the lid off any cover-up—was provided to Shandera and Moore in the form of a roll of 35mm film. Upon developing it, they found photographs of eight pages classified Top Secret, Eyes Only, and "Copy One of One." Ostensibly written by Roscoe H. Hillenkoetter, the first CIA director and a Navy admiral, it supposedly outlines for President-elect

Eisenhower the state of classified UFO research as of the fall of 1952. The document is dated November 18, 1952, which is in fact the date on which Eisenhower received his first briefing as President-elect, first at the White House and then at the Pentagon.

A key concept introduced by this document is that a group of men known as the "Majestic-12 Group" had complete control of information regarding hardware and bodies. This group, acting through the CIA director and the Secretary of Defense, is said to be responsible only to the President. Its 12 members allegedly included individuals from the Army, Navy, Air Force, and the executive branch as well as well-known scientists including Vannevar Bush—mentioned, you may recall, in the Smith memorandum as heading up a group to investigate UFOs. Another member, according to the EBD, was Gen. Twining, who along with Bush directed the initial "covert analytical effort" and reached a conclusion on September 19, 1947, that the "disc [recovered near Roswell] was likely a short range reconnaissance craft." Note that this date is only four days before Twining's letter to Schulgen discussed earlier. If the EBD is true, then clearly Twining knew of the hardware at the time of the September 23 letter.

I do not pretend to know with any certainty if the EBD is what it purports to be. If it is a fake, it is safe to say it is a remarkable one, and its author possessed considerable knowledge of the history of UFO events as well as non-UFO events from the same time period. Who, for example, would know that Eisenhower was briefed in the Pentagon and the White House on November 18 and hence could, in principle, have been briefed by Hillenkoetter?

The EBD also provides a reason for the creation of Project Sign, namely a need for more information. As the EBD puts it, "A need for as much additional information as possible about these craft, their performance characteristics, and their purpose led to the undertaking known as U.S. Air Force Project SIGN in December 1947." Sign was prevented from learning about the hardware by a method I discussed in my 1983 paper *Revised UFO History*, a year before the EBD showed up in Shandera's mail.

I also referred to moles in the chain of command between Blue Book and the higher echelons. The Air Force officer whose testimony I recited above read my paper and remarked that he had learned while at the Foreign Technology Division (formerly ATIC) that there had been *two* moles. At the time I was told this, the EBD had not been publicized; thus neither I nor the officer knew that the EBD contains this sentence: "In order to preserve security, liason [sic] between SIGN and Majestic-12 was limited to two individuals within the Intelligence Division of the Air Materiel Command whose role it was to pass along certain types of information through channels."

Whether the EBD is authentic or not, one thing is

certain: If the Roswell crash actually happened, an MJ-12—whether by that name or another—would inevitably have been established. In other words, if alien material were retrieved at Roswell—and this seems more certain now than it did eight years ago when I first reflected on the implications—the *functions* of an MJ-12 must have been carried out by some group under some name.

These functions are (1) controlling access to the information about hardware and bodies—that is, operating all the security functions and ensuring secure communications channels; (2) arranging for covert analyses of whatever materials, animal, vegetable, or mineral, that are available; (3) monitoring developments in the United States and throughout the world; (4) attempting to forecast future events based on what has happened and upon what can be reasonably conjectured; (5) preparing government strategy in the event of an earthshaking event such as an attack or a landing on the White House lawn; (6) continuing to update the President and his advisors.

Yet another function of such a group might be the creation of disinformation to prevent unauthorized persons from getting too close to the ultimate secret. Disinformation is designed to provide enough correct, checkable information so that the rest of the information, which is false, is believed. Certainly the EBD may be just this kind of disinformation. But if the EBD is disinformation designed to hide secrets by leading people to believe in extraterrestrial visitation, I hesitate to imagine what the actual covered-up information is.

Though I am convinced a cover group controls the UFO information and carries out research, I do not believe anyone has yet established this as a certain fact. In his *Out There* (1990) Howard Blum claims to have talked with two members of a secret "UFO Working Group" which was set up within the Defense Department. My own investigation of his claims leads me to believe this was, and is, basically a group of interested people who get together more or less on their own time; they are no different from the rest of us except that they have high-level security clearances and can meet in the Pentagon basement. The group Blum portrays in his book gives the impression of knowing no more about UFOs than we civilians do. In fact, they may know less. How else to explain their fascination with the relatively inconsequential Elmwood, Wisconsin, sightings when far more important ones beg for serious attention?

I am indirectly aware of an individual (name not known to me) who works with the Joint Chiefs of Staff and who has provided quite interesting information through a credible intermediary. The intermediary has solid credentials and claims to have known the source, called S, for many years. Only in the last few years, however, did he learn of the source's involvement with the subject of UFOs.

S has said there are hundreds of persons in the project, all with high security clearances; that these

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Aztec, New Mexico — a crash story reexamined

by William E. Jones and Rebecca D. Minshall

■ ■ William E. Jones and Rebecca D. Minshall are the authors of *Bill Cooper and the Need for More Research* (1991).

Editor's note: In 1950, in a best-selling book titled *Behind the Flying Saucers*, entertainment columnist Frank Scully reported that a spaceship had crashed on a rocky plateau east of Aztec, New Mexico, and the U.S. Air Force recovered it and the bodies of its occupants, 16 small humanlike beings dressed in the "style of 1890." Scully's source for this remarkable tale was a "Dr. Gee," identified as a government scientist. A subsequent investigation by J. P. Cahn, a writer for *True* magazine, found that Scully's informants were Leo A. GeBauer ("Dr. Gee") and Silas Newton, veteran confidence artists, and their saucer story was part of an elaborate swindle to peddle bogus oil-detection equipment to unsuspecting buyers. In the 1980s, as ufologists turned their attention to a question they had long ignored because of the Scully fiasco, some suggested that perhaps the Aztec case deserved another look. The result was a 625-page book, *UFO Crash at Aztec*, written by William S. Steinman and Wendelle C. Stevens and published privately in 1987. Its title notwithstanding, only a part of the volume deals directly with the event. That section is written by Steinman, with Stevens padding the rest of the book with other tales of crashes and conspiracies. According to Steinman, GeBauer and Newton were railroaded by an unscrupulous journalist and a sinister government agency "determined . . . to set an example for anybody else who might decide to divulge information . . . and to divert public attention completely away from the story of the crashed saucers and little bodies." Chapter 6 of the book consists of Steinman's account of what he found when he went to Aztec to investigate personally. In what follows, the authors take issue with Steinman's version of events.

With the developing story of the 1947 Roswell, New Mexico, UFO crash it is natural that some UFO investigators should direct their attention to other crash stories which are not so well documented and well known. We at MidOhio Research Associates have been investigating the alleged crash of a flying saucer at Aztec, New Mexico, in 1948, the subject of a book by William S. Steinman and

Wendelle C. Stevens, *UFO Crash at Aztec*.

We hoped to learn something about the Aztec story. Given the cost and difficulty of investigating a 1948 New Mexico case from our base in Ohio, we had little hope of conclusively proving or disproving it, but we wanted to see what we could uncover through telephone and letter inquiries. MORA was fortunate to secure the assistance of Suzanne Belt, executive director of the Aztec Museum Association. Her investigation is underway, and we plan to report on her findings in the near future. What is being learned about the Aztec crash story is worth recording in the event that the Aztec crash takes on some claimed importance in the future.

The Denver lecture

On pages 91, 267, and 268 of his book Steinman writes about a lecture delivered anonymously by Silas M. Newton before a "Basic Science" class at the University of Denver. According to the book, Newton was invited to give the lecture by the class instructor, Francis F. Broman. The purpose of the lecture was to provide the students with an assertion against which they could apply the critical thinking methods Broman was teaching. When word got out around the campus that a lecture on flying saucers was going to be given, the interest was so great that a larger lecture hall had to be used. In June 1991 we talked with Broman, who essentially verified what Steinman had written about the incident. Newton did, in fact, request anonymity at the lecture because, so he said, he didn't want the government to know who he was. He had the lecture taped and, as far as is known, kept the tape for himself. Finally, for the record, the class was entitled "Science and Man."

Broman found Newton's claim about the crashed saucer unconvincing, as did many of those who attended his lecture. Further, Newton failed to live up to an agreement to allow his story to be critiqued using the methods being taught by Broman. As a result of statements made later by Broman about some aspects of the lecture, Broman was reportedly threatened with a lawsuit by the author of a book entitled *About UFOs*. The dispute was settled out of court. Because of criticisms in the *Denver Post* and resulting pressures from within the university community, his memory of the event is not pleasant.

Steinman writes that Broman was contacted by a

representative of the FBI or Army intelligence—Broman does not remember which—right after the lecture. The caller reportedly wanted to know what he and others thought of the lecture. When we asked him about this on July 1, Broman confirmed the book's account. The caller tried to reach him by telephone at his home soon after the 10 a.m. lecture. Since Broman had to drop off his laboratory assistant before he could go home, he missed the call. Broman was called back a second time soon after he arrived home. The caller did ask what Broman and others thought about the lecture. Broman replied that he didn't believe the crash story and didn't think many others did either. That seemed to satisfy the caller.

Testimony from Aztec

On page 256 Steinman discusses "W.M." who was a deputy sheriff in 1948 and who supposedly left the Aztec area quickly, settling in Long Beach, California, only to return years later after retirement. A small article in the April 28, 1948, issue of the *Durango Herald*, a Colorado newspaper, led Steinman to conclude W.M. had left Aztec in fear after being threatened because of his knowledge of the UFO crash. The article reported that W.M.'s car hit a cow on the Gallup Highway as he was driving to California. The accident knocked W.M.'s teeth out and demolished his vehicle. "He bought another car in Gallup and finished the trip," according to the *Herald*. Steinman comments, "W.M. must have been in an awful hurry to get out of Aztec, even to the extent of buying another car along the road, and not even tending to his teeth!" He intimates that W.M. knew something about the crash and goes, "The article didn't say whether W.M. left Aztec before or after the UFO crash. Did he see something that resulted in his having to leave at that time—or did something happen nearby while he was gone that he may have come into knowledge of which had the same effect? . . . Was he told by somebody . . . to mind his own business?"

"W.M.," who Steinman writes is "now deceased," is Wright G. McEwen. McEwen, who is in fact still alive, and lives in Aztec with his wife. They were contacted by telephone. McEwen was a deputy sheriff in March 1948, and he did leave Aztec to move to California. He confirmed that he had talked with Steinman and knew the general outlines of the story. But both he and his wife emphatically deny that a flying saucer crashed near Hart Canyon, northeast of Aztec. Mrs. McEwen added that Aztec was a small town back in 1948 and if something that momentous had occurred, everyone in town would soon have been aware of it. She thinks that the crash story may have been started by a newspaper man who she believes was named George Bower; he sometimes wrote partially true and sensational stories for the local paper to help boost circulation. (Other investigators of the story believe the more likely source was a much-publicized crash hoax used to promote a 1949 science-fiction film,

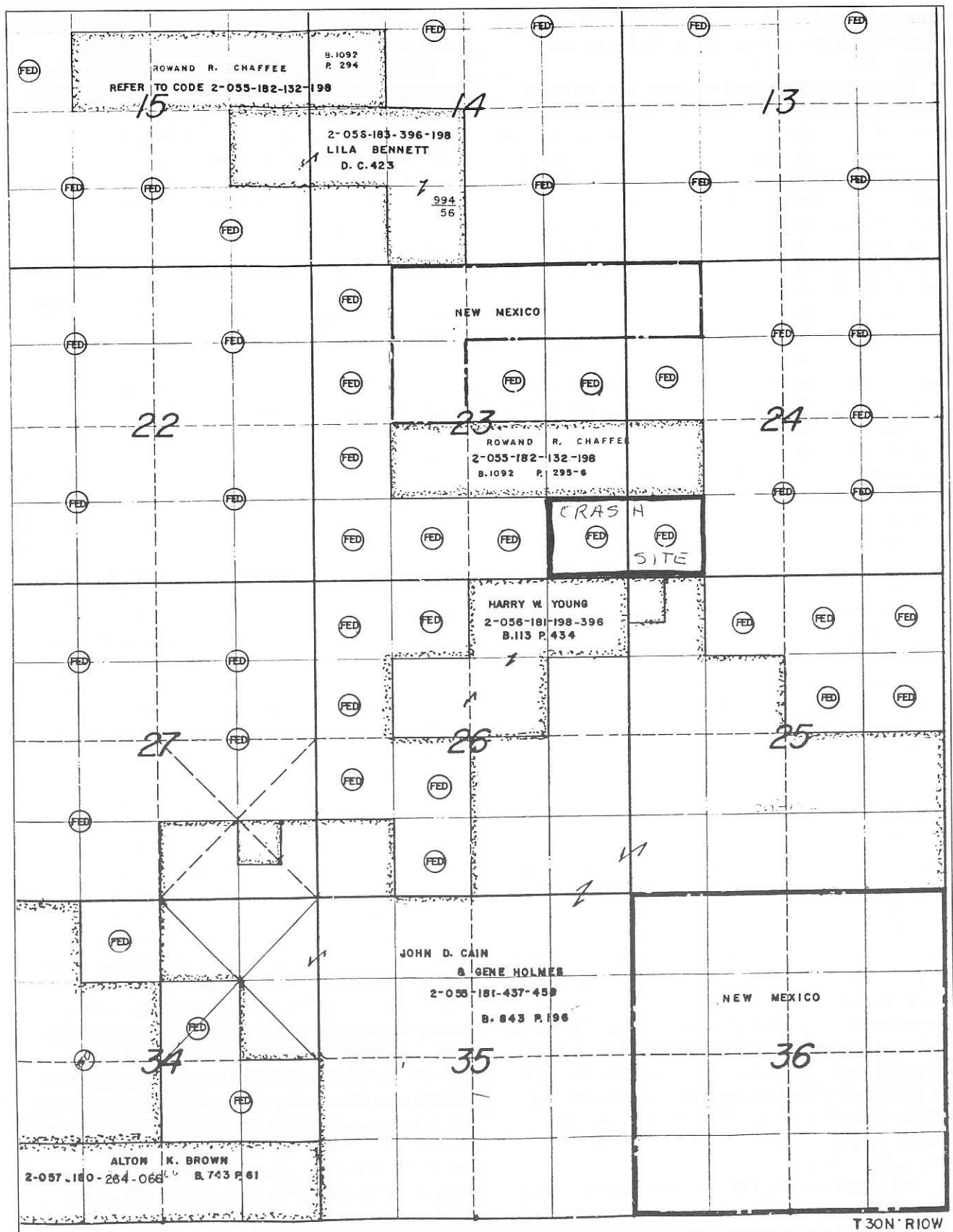
The Flying Saucer. In a paper published in *MUFON 1985 UFO Symposium Proceedings*, William L. Moore suggests that the episode gave Newton and GeBauer the idea of a saucer crash. GeBauer had done business in Aztec, according to Moore, and this may have played a role in their decision to set the event there.)

In those days, Mrs. McEwen told us, there were no roads east out of Hart Canyon over which large objects could have been transported. She said the roads didn't come in until a later oil-search boom. As the manager of a motel out on U.S. Route 550 at the time, she would have been aware, one way or another, of anyone who came into town to assist in the retrieval operation, she said.

Steinman claims that he learned about McEwen through Harvey Melton, who had moved into Aztec in 1970 or 1972. (See pages 204-05 and pages 242-43.) According to Mrs. McEwen, Melton, an acquaintance of theirs, was interested in flying saucers and during the Steinman visit had become somewhat "abusive" with them over the Aztec story. She thinks that he was too willing to believe in such stories. Steinman writes that Melton and his wife Vivian learned about the location of the crash site from a "mysterious" Ray Meier who arrived in Aztec by bus in June 1975. The Meltons and a man named Benson Leeper reportedly escorted Meier to the site where he took pictures and studied the area for about an hour. He stayed with the Meltons overnight and, according to Steinman, left by bus the next day. Their attempts to reach him later at an Albuquerque post office box address he gave them were unsuccessful. The MORA investigators also tried to reach Meier at this address; the letter was returned unclaimed. Meier was not listed in the Albuquerque telephone records as of July 1, 1991.

Mrs. McEwen told us that she and her husband are interested in flying saucers and have an open mind on the subject. When told about the mounting evidence for the 1947 Roswell crash, she said that she could accept that if there was enough evidence. But she is sure that no saucer crashed near Aztec in 1948; she would have heard about it.

Benson Leeper still lives on his farm north of Aztec. He remembered when a man came to town and asked him and the Meltons to take him out to the site. He could not recall the man's name, even when told that the name was Ray Meier. Leeper did not go to the site, and he is not sure whether or not Vivian Melton went. He recalled, however, that Harvey Melton did go out with Meier, though he did so reluctantly because he was a little bit afraid of the man. When we asked Leeper what kind of man Meier was, Leeper's telephone demeanor changed immediately. Until that point he had acted a little disinterested and bored. He quickly answered with a definitive, "I won't say!" We then asked if Meier was "strange," and he replied, "You could say that." He would say no more on the subject even when pressed. He urged us to talk with Vivian, who is now living some-



where in Nevada; Harvey has since died. He claimed not to know her address, saying that the McEwens would know.

We talked further about the crash story and about Steinman. Leeper claims not to know how Steinman came to the conclusion that he knew something about the crash. He mentioned that Steinman kept questioning him about "the humanoids" which he claims to know nothing about. "I don't even know what a humanoid is," he said. As far as he remembers, Steinman came to Aztec to investigate two or three times. At one point in the discussion about Steinman, Leeper got upset and perhaps a bit concerned. He asked, "Did he put my address in his book? How did you find me?" We replied that Steinman mentioned only his name and that we found his telephone number in the local telephone book. As the conversation came to a close, we asked Mr. Leeper if he believed the story about the crash. He replied that he did not and that it is treated as a "joke" by many of Aztec's old-timers. We then asked how he thought the story got started. He said that a P-38, a World War II-era fighter aircraft, landed up on U.S. Route 550 back in the 1940s because of engine trouble or a lack of fuel. "The plane sat up on the Close farm for about a week," he claimed. Then the military came in, disassembled the craft, and trucked it out. That is all he claims to know.

We called the McEwens and inquired about Vivian Melton. They referred us to a daughter, Pat Melton, who currently lives in Aztec. Contacted by telephone on July 3, she confirmed some of what Steinman wrote about her parents and added that she had met Meier when he was in Aztec. At first she was afraid of him, as her father was, but after talking with him three or four times, got to like him. She also confirmed that he came into Aztec by bus about 15 years ago; Steinman says it was in June 1975. So their statements agree.

But Pat Melton takes these exceptions to what Steinman wrote: Meier was there four or five days, not just overnight. According to her, Wright McEwen and her father accompanied Meier to the site; her mother and Benson Leeper didn't go along. (A second call to Mrs. McEwen did not confirm her husband's part in this trip; she thinks her husband went out to the site only when Bill Steinman came to town.) Pat Melton's parents had a Nissan, not a Toyota. She doesn't know if the Nissan was used to go to the site or if a vehicle had been rented by Meier and was used for this purpose. Melton added that her parents left Aztec sometime after Steinman's visit because of her father's health, not because they had learned something special about the crash story, as implied by Steinman.

Bill Steinman upset a lot of people when he was in Aztec, Melton said. Some of the people he interviewed, including her parents, claimed he was an aggressive interviewer, putting words into their mouths to prove the points he wanted them to make. They complained that he made "a lot of speculative assumptions" based upon very

few facts. The matter-of-fact people of Aztec did not take kindly to Steinman's approach and his conclusions.

Meier told Melton and her parents that he had been a science teacher, was a vegetarian, and was interested in metaphysics. Melton doesn't know if he was retired from the Marine Corps, as claimed by Steinman. She found him "aloof." Meier did not reveal why he thought the flying saucer came down on the plot of land in question. That is unfortunate because Meier's claim that it is the crash site is one of the keys to the entire Aztec crash story as told by Steinman.

Meier's interest in Aztec was obviously influenced by Frank Scully's book which dealt with the Aztec crash shortly after its alleged occurrence. In a May 31, 1975, letter to Pat's parents, the original of which is in our possession, Meier states, "I'll be heading for Denver shortly and hope to find the Aztec article on Dr. Gee which I read in [the] Spring of 1950."

The site

Steinman places the crash site northeast of Aztec on Hart Canyon Road, about six miles east of U.S. Route 550. He claims to have learned about the site through Mrs. Melton during his trip to Aztec in 1982. He locates the site on a copy of a county survey map that he had obtained from the San Juan County Assessors Office. This map is reproduced on page 245 of *UFO Crash at Aztec*. To the south of the crash site is property noted as being owned by Harry W. Young and a smaller parcel owned by the El Paso Oil Company. To the north of the site is a larger parcel noted as being owned by H. Knowlton and Rowland Robert Chaffee. A few other privately owned parcels are shown on the map, as well as a lot of space that is not marked as being owned by anyone.

Early in his book, on page 35, Steinman, writing about the disposition of the crash site, asserts, "General Marshall [Gen. George C. Marshall, then U.S. Secretary of State under President Truman] called the Secretary of the Interior asking him to transfer the piece of property on which the crash site was located, from the ownership of H. D. to Federal Status!! [We assume that this transfer was agreed to by the owner identified as "H.D." in the book, but Steinman is not clear on this point.] Marshall accomplished this in such a way as not to arouse suspicions concerning the real reason, and carried it off successfully." Steinman makes it appear that this land transfer took place during the short period when the vehicle was being recovered, but does not specifically make this claim. The ownership history of this parcel of land is the another key to the credibility of Steinman's story. He seems to realize this and reports on page 263 on his unsuccessful attempt to trace this history.

"H.D." is Harold Dunning. He is identified in footnote number 2 to Appendix B of *UFO Crash at Roswell* by Kevin D. Randle and Donald R. Schmitt and on a map in Steinman's book on page 34. We discovered

these references on July 5, 1991. Coincidentally, during the July 3 conversation with Pat Melton, she had referred to a Hi Dunning and said he might know something about the crash. Harold Dunning, 93 years old, does not have a telephone, but his son Jack does and was easily located through cold calls to the only two Dunnings in the phone book. Jack Dunning said that his father knows nothing about such a crash, though they are both aware of the rumors, having met Steinman when he came to Aztec on his investigation. Jack claimed that his father had owned a little over two parcels of land in Hart Canyon, including the land on which the El Paso Oil Company pipeline station is located. The El Paso land is adjacent to and south of the land claimed by Steinman to be the crash site, so the land once owned by Dunning and referred to by Steinman as the crash site may be, at least in part, one and the same. Jack thinks his father sold his land to someone named Hank Knowlton, the H. Knowlton listed as part owner of the parcels adjacent to and north of the crash site on the map in the Steinman book. Jack believes the transfer of this land took place in the early 1950s.

His father also leased land in Hart Canyon, possibly 18 parcels, from the federal government back in those days. He ran cattle on this land. Jack could not remember which plots were leased.

Henry Knowlton confirmed in a telephone conversation on July 9 that he is the person who purchased land in Hart Canyon from Harold Dunning, probably in the early 1950s. He later sold the land to Rowland Chaffee. He is certain that none of this property included the site where the crash was said to have occurred. He is certain of this because he knows the location of this area, which he called a "bluff." As far as he knows, the bluff parcels were never owned privately, though they may have been leased for grazing purposes. He and his friends collected Indian pottery fragments and arrow heads from the area, so he is familiar with it. He stated further that there is, or at least was, a blackened area on this site about 10 feet by 10 feet in size where the pottery fragments were most heavily concentrated. The consensus among his friends is that this is where the pottery was baked.

When asked whether there is a fence on the site, Knowlton said there is an old fenced-in area near where the pottery fragments were found. There were a number of these fenced-in areas in the desert near Aztec, having been placed there by the federal government. The government was attempting to determine how well the grasses of the area would grow when protected from grazing cattle.

Knowlton stated that the El Paso Oil Company natural gas pipeline station property was once owned by Chick Townsend. According to Knowlton, this was a part of the land he purchased from Dunning, which he, in turn, then sold to Townsend. He believes the sale to El Paso by Townsend took place in 1960. The pipeline station was built after this sale. There is a bit of a mystery in all of this, in that the Dunning/Knowlton/Townsend/El Paso

land and the Dunning/Knowlton/Chaffee land are separated by the crash site, which reportedly has never been owned by anyone else but the federal government. Further, there have been no statements to the effect that all of the land originally owned by Dunning was ever split into two separate parts.

When asked if he knew anything about the crash of a flying saucer in the area, Knowlton laughed and said that this story had been around for years and simply wasn't true. He had no idea how it got started.

One problem with part of Steinman's story comes to mind. The alleged crash site is clearly out in the middle of nowhere. If the government was trying to protect the site from being searched by future investigators by building a fence, it certainly failed to accomplish its goal. No one is there to watch over the site and the fence supposedly put up by the federal government to protect it from human trespassers is useless for that purpose, though it would keep cattle out. The fence and federal ownership certainly did not keep Meier and Steinman out. If either had wanted to do so, an archaeological dig could have been conducted to locate buried crash-related artifacts, and it is doubtful that the government would have known about it for a very long time. Logic dictates that the fence was there for a purpose other than to keep out human trespassers, probably for the reason Knowlton cites. This factor removes part of the aura of conspiracy about the site that Steinman has attempted to portray in his book.

In May 1991 we ordered a map like that obtained by Steinman from the San Juan County Assessors Office. The legal description of the area covered by the map is "Township No. 31N, Range R10W." The land to the south of the crash site is still listed in the name of Harry W. Young. The land to the north is now listed solely in the name of Rowland R. Chaffee. The El Paso Oil Company name no longer appears on the map, though the property is still shown separately. The site where the crash was alleged to have occurred is listed as "FED." On this map, that designation is for federal government land, seemingly supporting Steinman's claim. However, all of the land on the map in Steinman's book that is blank is federal land. It appears that the Assessor's Office map used in his book was altered to downplay this fact. In fact, most of the land north of Aztec is owned by the federal government, and a significant part of the remainder is owned by the state of New Mexico. Private land is relatively rare. In addition, unless the crash site parcels were originally attached to either the Chaffee or Young properties, these parcels could, by no stretch of the imagination, be considered a "ranch," as characterized by Steinman. The crash-site land is much too small for any such purpose.

We wrote the U.S. Department of the Interior, Bureau of Land Management, Farmington Resource Area, in Farmington, New Mexico, to see if it had any

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What can ufologists learn from parapsychology?

by Mahlon W. Wagner

■ ■ Mahlon W. Wagner, Ph.D., is a professor of psychology at the State University of New York at Oswego.

A famous comedian complains, "I get no respect." This worthwhile goal of respect is sought not only by proponents of UFOs but also by other investigators of border areas of science. The world is waiting to find out what UFOs are really all about. I am not here to agree with the skeptics, nor am I here to argue with believers in UFOs. But both sides must come together to deal with many problems. A rapprochement must be established. In what follows I plan to seek guidance for ways that proponents and skeptics can come together in a fruitful dialogue which could pave the way to an acceptance of ufology by mainstream science.

Though J. Allen Hynek is reputed to have said, "I am very much afraid that UFOs are related to certain psychic phenomena," there has been a general distancing of each group of researchers and/or believers from the other. I would propose that those who study UFOs could learn a great deal by examining the history of the study of psychic phenomena. Students of UFOs may gain better insights into the methods of sharing and communicating their own studies to others by knowing of the pitfalls, blind alleys, and traps as well as the successes encountered by parapsychology, the scientific study of psychic phenomena. I intend to show that, in fact, there are more commonalities than differences between ufology and parapsychology. Based on these commonalities, I shall conclude with a recommendation for future more concrete research into the UFO phenomenon.

Previous attempts to relate UFOs to parapsychological phenomena have been less than convincing, primarily because they have concentrated on the various specific kinds of events themselves rather than taking a broader view from a historical context. Cases have been reported of telepathic communication by UFO inhabitants with abducted human beings. Self-proclaimed psychic Uri Geller attributes his paranormal abilities to contacts with a UFO named Spectra from the planet Hoova. Finally, mysterious mechanical breakdowns of cars, radar, and various electronics are reported to occur coincident with UFO sightings. While these anecdotes are intriguing, they are of minimal use in charting a future for UFO research that will have social and political significance.

The observations

Examples from the history of parapsychology will be used to clarify some of the problems currently found in UFO study. For example, one of the most profound frustrations for ufologists has to be the fact that their data are largely "observational" as opposed to "experimental" or "laboratory" information. Most of science demands repeatable experiments, phenomena upon demand, and predictive ability. The current study of UFOs has difficulty meeting these requirements.

Until the 1920s parapsychology also was limited to observation. Prior to this time psychic investigation was plagued with fraudulent mediums, psychics, and mind readers and inadequate research methods. The researcher had to be content with waiting around for the next psychic occurrence which might not be repeated or made to appear upon demand. Eyewitness testimony of spontaneous events was the primary source of evidence for the reality of psychic phenomena.

Through the application of the then-emerging science of psychology it was eventually realized that under ideal conditions, even trustworthy human beings frequently commit serious errors of observation and that memory is fragile and similarly unreliable. Most observations of psychics and mediums were made in dimly lit rooms by an untrained and nonskeptical audience. Time and again many honest, sincere, and highly educated scientists and lay persons were duped by con artists, confused by misdirection, or victimized by self-deception. An additional, and perhaps more important, problem was that well-intentioned citizens, unable to distinguish coincidence and natural phenomena, were reporting fantastic events which seemed to be of a psychic nature. I would argue that the state of affairs in ufology, based until now primarily upon observations, suffers from the same criticisms faced by early parapsychologists.

Before concluding that psychic investigators no longer encounter these problems, one need only turn to books by Louisa Rhine (for example, *The Invisible Picture* [1981]) and others. These books are little more than compilations of numerous isolated wondrous and mysterious events seeming to find explanations only in the psychic realm. People report unusual noises, mechanical breakdowns, and unusual animal behavior often at the moment of death of a loved one. Dreams which later seem to come true and premonitions of disaster also play

prominent roles in these accounts. Most of these people are quite unaware of the nature of selective memory or coincidence. It is also not uncommon to ignore or be unaware of natural explanations for events and to conclude too readily that a psychic explanation is the most reasonable one. Again, in the field of ufology, reports are overwhelmingly made by untrained lay people with little understanding of the role of chance or coincidence or that there may be a natural explanation for the event.

The solution advocated by most parapsychologists for all of the shortcomings of an "observational" subject has been to move into the experimental research laboratory. But even here scientists have been misled and fooled by unscrupulous investigators or poor experimental methodology. It has seriously been suggested that magicians be consulted to improve experimental controls and designs by reducing intentional trickery or fraud. It has been reported that even Hynek in an interview shortly before his death also recommended that magicians be included in UFO research. Perhaps Hynek could have written this article even more convincingly than I could.

The question of reality

The question can be asked: "Whom are we trying to convince that psychic phenomena (or UFOs) are real?" It must be frustrating to find relatively wide public acceptance for UFOs as well as psychic phenomena on one hand while on the other the scientific community has either remained indifferent to or overwhelmingly rejected both sets of ideas and generally refuses to examine new claims which are continually appearing.

In spite of frequent ridicule in the media, the latest (1990) Gallup poll suggests that 49 percent of the general public already believes in ESP and that 47 percent believes UFOs are something real (down 10 percent since 1978). It must be tempting to suggest that "we" know more than those closed-minded scientists, that "we" have actually progressed further than those scientists. Proponents of unconventional phenomena have attempted to find solace in the history of meteorites and the steamboat, ideas once rejected but ultimately accepted as legitimate. In the decades prior to 1800 farmers and other citizens reported fiery stones falling from the sky, and some even brought them to scientists for study, only to be scornfully turned away because these educated scientists "knew" such claims were utter nonsense. Is there a parallel between meteorites and UFOs and psychic phenomena?

Probably not. Sociologist of science Ron Westrum and others have pointed out that scientists did indeed investigate these reports, and within less than 20 years of intense controversy meteorites became widely accepted in science—hardly a case of closed-minded scientists.

Throughout history skeptics have noted that the proponents of unconventional phenomena (such as UFOs and the paranormal) have adopted a "siege mentality."

That is, they claim to have been persecuted and perhaps even been paranoid. First, the scientific and academic communities have largely rejected their ideas and perhaps even punished their own members who profess sympathy for a belief in these anomalous events. An example is the fall from favor of Sir Alfred Russel Wallace, cofounder of the theory of evolution after his involvement with psychic phenomena and phrenology. Second, it is also argued that perhaps segments of the government and intelligence agencies may be deliberately working against full and open examination of these nonconforming phenomena. Unfortunately, claims of government secrecy, harassment, and disinformation have not been objectively established. The more extreme forms of this argument, advanced by the least critical UFO advocates, are almost certain to cause scientists and academics to have serious reservations about persons or groups making these charges and claims.

Historically unconventional border areas of science have been too readily stigmatized by the more traditional "establishment" scientists as belonging to some lunatic fringe. Believers were considered to be unstable, ignorant, and superstitious for accepting such "outlandish nonsense." Responses to these charges have ranged from quiet indignation to howling outrage—none guaranteed to change the minds of the skeptics.

Perhaps one can understand why skeptics have developed these perceptions. William R. Corliss, who for years has catalogued scientific anomalies, observes, "For every anomaly or example that can be legitimately demolished, 10 more take its place." To the skeptics it seems as if believers—lay persons especially—are immune to logic or rational thought; they airily dismiss negative cases or experiments that refute the reality of the phenomena because not *every* anomalous event has been similarly shown to have natural origins. This is similar to J. B. Rhine's counterargument to the skeptics that while most ESP experiments may be methodologically weak, taken together they make a strong case for the reality of ESP. This is taken from the argument that while single twigs may be weak, a bundle of them cannot be broken. But such an analogy is not valid when scientific evidence is being examined.

The witnesses

But while we can understand the skeptic's concern for rigorous research and methodology, this does not automatically support the idea that believers are somehow disturbed, insecure, unintelligent, or gullible. In fact, recent research which unfortunately has not received wide publicity has shown that there are few differences between believers and disbelievers. Believers in UFOs are not more unhappy, distressed, dissatisfied, alienated, or malevolent. Believers in UFOs, however, are higher in education, generally younger, and more likely to be science-fiction fans, but not more involved in the occult.

Even those who have had a UFO experience score in the normal range on various personality tests and show no over psychopathology. (Of course, this may beg the question of whether, in fact, personality tests can tell anything important about a person; but that is a topic best left alone for now.)

In a related finding, persons who report having out-of-body experiences have also been found to exhibit no signs of mental or emotional instability or abnormality. Unlike UFO believers, however, believers in the psychic do tend also to believe strongly in the occult and to be female.

The audience

So while history and research have not borne out the misperceptions of skeptics, this does not relieve ufologists and parapsychologists from the onus of responsible scholarship and reasoned discourse. But at whom should this discourse be directed? Two questions remain: (1) Whom should proponents be trying to convince? and (2) What is the best way to convince the target audience?

To be accepted as legitimate fields of scientific endeavor, it is science that must be convinced. Parapsychology has accepted this challenge. The Parapsychology Association (PA) sought and was given associate status by the American Association for the Advancement of Science (AAAS), the most prestigious, all-encompassing scientific association in America. The PA has rigorous standards for membership. There are several peer-reviewed journals devoted to sound research in parapsychology. Though charlatans, pretenders, psychics, trance channelers, and mediums still exist and receive media attention (some even have 900 phone numbers), these people have been relegated to the irresponsible fringe inhabited by quack physicians and con artists. Parapsychology has been willing to play the science game with reasonable scientists and to accept the challenge of science that "extraordinary claims demand extraordinary evidence."

Parapsychology has also invited skeptics, critics, and magicians into a dialogue aimed at more productive and rigorous research activities. And finally, parapsychology has refrained from complaining that it is not getting a fair hearing from closed-minded bigoted enemies or from summarily dismissing its critics as ignorant.

What does this suggest for those who seek respectability for the study of UFOs? Unfortunately, the study of UFOs remains as yet an observational activity. The phenomena are not repeated upon demand, and no one has been creative enough as yet to bring these events into the laboratory except on an after-the-fact basis. But before despair sets in, we must acknowledge that there are several respected sciences that are essentially observational: astronomy, climatology, geology, archaeology, paleontology, and evolutionary biology. The possibility exists, therefore, that ufology has the potential for

acceptance by mainstream science.

What measures must be taken to be seriously considered? First, there is the need to establish an intimate cooperation with the behavioral sciences. Psychology, especially, can offer valuable guidance on problems associated with eyewitness testimony and the accompanying errors of observation, perception, memory, and recall as well as the dangers of acceptance as valid of hypnotically aided recall of UFO experiences.

Second, it would be highly beneficial to establish an open and continuing dialogue with skeptics and critics. The assistance of these groups should be sought out and incorporated in continuing UFO investigations. The humility involved in recognizing that critics may have something important to contribute is often welcomed by science as a first step away from the frequently encountered pride and arrogance of extremists and pseudoscientists. In a similar vein a serious impediment to legitimacy is the frequent derogation and/or out-of-hand dismissal of critics by overly enthusiastic and partisan groups. Just as parapsychology has attempted to distance itself from its lunatic fringe, so also must serious UFO investigators.

To paraphrase Barry Goldwater's famous 1964 quotation: humility in the defense of an idea is no vice, while pride in the pursuit of one's own idea of truth is no virtue. Too often one sees too much pride and not enough humility among UFO investigators. Recently a UFO magazine editor wrote (emphasis added): "The day is coming when the scientific community abandons its near-criminal negligence and concedes its *shameful* failure to address the single most important scientific question of the 20th Century." Sentiments of this type are guaranteed to alienate scientists, not to encourage their cooperation.

Speaking personally, I would like nothing more than to see a cooperative scientific examination of the UFO phenomenon. It is to be hoped that we can learn from history how best to accomplish this goal. ■

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Letters

Randle's military career

To the editor:

Some readers of *UFO Crash at Roswell* have been curious about my military background. Before too many rumors start to fly, let me take this opportunity to put the facts on the record.

I graduated from high school in Aurora, Colorado, in 1967 and less than a month later entered the Army. I attended Warrant Officer Flight Training, first at Fort Wolters, Texas, and later at Fort Rucker, Alabama. In August 1968 I graduated as a warrant officer and helicopter pilot and received orders for Vietnam.

I spent 11 months and 20 days in Vietnam, serving with the 116th Assault Helicopter Company in Cu Chi and later with the 187th Assault Helicopter Company in Tay Ninh. I flew, at one time or another, every type of mission helicopters were used in; for a couple of months I was the flight leader. I ended my Army service in 1971 and enrolled at the University of Iowa.

During my college career I entered Air Force ROTC, graduated from college, and received a commission on graduation. I entered the Air Force for a short period of active duty and then joined the reserve, serving as the Air Intelligence Officer of the 442nd Tactical Airlift Wing and later as the Director of Intelligence for the 928th Tactical Airlift Group. During that period I spent time in Panama and at Red Flag at Nellis Air Force Base and was promoted twice, ending my active reserve service as a captain in 1986. I am retained in the inactive reserve as a captain and was alerted for possible activation in January 1991.

This should clarify my background for those who are interested.

Kevin D. Randle
Marion, Iowa

Remembering Ruppelt

To the editor:

I enjoyed your editorial "Let Us Now Praise Ed Ruppelt" in the July/August issue of *IUR*. Ruppelt has never been fully appreciated by the various civilian groups.

According to some, the three chapters added to the 1960 version of *The Report on Unidentified Flying Objects* were not written by Ruppelt but by others.

Another individual from the early Blue Book era was Dewey Fournet, who like Ruppelt has never received his

full due. Fournet and Ruppelt worked closely together, and the two went to the Robertson panel meeting convinced that UFOs were of extraterrestrial origin. The panel's negative conclusions did nothing to change their minds on that score.

I have in my possession the briefcase Fournet took to the panel meeting. It carried his handwritten notes which he used in his presentation, along with the cases that had convinced him and Ruppelt of the extraterrestrial hypothesis.

Ruppelt's book deserves all the credit you gave it. As far as I am concerned, it is the best book ever written on the subject.

Bill Pitts
Fort Smith, Arkansas

To the editor:

I noted your editorial tribute to Ed Ruppelt. Recently I reread his book myself.

At that time I wondered what the fact of the matter was regarding the RB-29 case he mentioned in the closing pages, in the chapter "What Are UFOs?" It's a good case, a shining UFO shooting past a "photo ship," seen by its crew and photographed by one of its cameras. Ruppelt wrote that Blue Book "carried out one of the most complete investigations in UFO history." Yet I don't know of its ever being mentioned by anyone again. It seems to me it should have been a case Allen Hynek or James McDonald would have cited, but to my knowledge neither did. I suppose it could be buried somewhere in the Condon report, but I can't find it there. Do any of your readers know anything more about it?

But it is another case that impels me to write: a case of three IFOs. It is out of a CIA briefing paper cited in Philip J. Klass' *UFOs: The Public Deceived* (1983). Ruppelt is directly involved in this one, but again, to my knowledge it is mentioned nowhere in his book or anywhere else in the literature. Klass relates it (in Chapter 2) as follows:

"[This case] points to interesting psychological factors. The time was near dusk. Ruppelt was called out to witness a sighting of three red lights in the sky. Even through binoculars, he could not determine their nature. An F-94 interceptor climbed to 43,000 feet. At this altitude the pilot could see clearly that the objects were a cluster of three Skyhook balloons still well above him, sailing an even course through the sky. The objects were described as violently maneuvering 'saucers' of various shapes and colors. Even 'looping' maneuvers were reported. The medical staff at Wright Field, including the senior psychologist, witnessed the sighting. The next day this staff turned in a report stating that, despite the official statement that these objects were balloons, they felt that this was in error and that the sighting must have been of some other unknown origin."

This sort of thing really gets me. Venus for me is always well behaved, and the one loose balloon I was lucky enough to see looked like a white spot in the sky to both me and my companion. There were no maneuvers, violent or otherwise. The Skyhook balloons and the responses to them would have made a great story for Ruppelt's book, but it doesn't seem to be there.

I'd have thought that the case would be part of the Blue Book files and good fodder for debunkers, but no one else seems to cite it either. The CIA briefing paper is dated August 15, 1952. The Condon report has one listing for Wright Field in the index, an unrelated case, and the date given for that is simply August 1952. That must be just a coincidence, no reason for me to suspect that the CIA briefer had heard of a Wright Field case and then made up a good one of his own.

I would be most interested in any information anyone has on those cases.

C. Barry Withers
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Toronto, Ontario M8V 1E8

Crop-circle vortexes

To the editor:

I am curious to know if Jenny Randles is a meteorologist, climatologist, or any other type of weather expert. I seriously doubt it based on what she writes in *IUR* ("Nature's Crop Circles, Nature's UFOs," May/June).

Randles is adamant in her insistence that her vortex theory of crop circles is the only plausible explanation here. I take issue. Growing up in the southeastern United States, I lived in an area that was frequently visited by vortices. As an eyewitness to this rotating atmospheric phenomenon, I discovered that rarely, if at all, will a vortex remain stationary long enough to create patterns as well defined as those in England.

Vortices actually operate like mini tornadoes but on a much smaller scale. They are driven by heat differentials which are constantly changing. Therefore it is unlikely that a vortex will remain in one place long enough to create perfect patterns without leaving trails and other traces. My skepticism of Randles' theory is shared by several Los Angeles-area meteorologists with whom I have discussed it.

My advice to Randles is: don't wait for someone to come along and prove your vortex theory wrong; instead, do your science and prove your theory right.

Warren Betts
Los Angeles, California

Magnetic effects

To the editor:

Have any *IUR* readers other than me collected magnetic-effect reports? I will pay \$20 each, up to \$1000 per person, for photocopies of published UFO reports which I do not have and which mention that a magnetic-compass needle or a magnetic detector was affected.

Because I already have a substantial collection of such published magnetic (*not* electro-magnetic) effect cases, readers who are interested in this offer should first request my list of reports.

Eric Herr
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Michael D. Swords, Ph.D., editor

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EDITORIAL—continued from page 3

paranoid ufologists' traditional anxieties about tapped phones and CIA assassinations of those who know too much about flying saucers.

What he himself believes, alas, is hardly less crazy. Much of his problem is that he has a hard time entirely disbelieving anybody. To Vallee even those whom others have had no trouble identifying as crude charlatans are "sincere." To those who do not see a conspiracy everywhere, it is quite easy to accept that somebody might peddle tales of man-eating aliens—or of Space Brothers or of ETs in our midst—simply to fatten the bank account, to gratify the ego, to fool the gullible, or to feed any other unworthy but recognizable human impulse. There is no reason, logically or evidentially, to suspect these hoaxers are some other hoaxers' victims. But if one wishes, with Vallee, to indulge in conspiratorial musings, then the contactees and the Cooperists *really* had an experience (with actors in alien outfits) or *really* saw a secret document (contrived for disinformation purposes), even if to get there one has to ignore clear and specific evidence that the claimants are lying through their teeth.

Vallee drags the Cergy-Pontoise tale—a *confessed* hoax yet—into the conspiracy. In this instance, he writes, the agents were "beings of flesh and blood within the French military and technological establishment." How does Vallee know this? He has it from a nameless source who claims to have spoken with an anonymous bureaucrat in the French Ministry of Defense.

This, by the way, is the same Vallee who complains (on page 76) of Len Stringfield's habit of citing anonymous sources. Yet anonymous sources, making claims in some ways as incredible as those who tell Stringfield of crashed saucers and extraterrestrial autopsies, abound in *Revelations'* pages. Some instances: (1) "[A]ntiterrorist exercises in which the attackers disguised their craft as a flying saucer have actually been run more than once," which explains cases cited by "amateur groups" as "proof that extraterrestrials are surveying our strategic assets." Source: "men who were trained in the penetration of nuclear plants and missile bases," none named. (2) There is evidence that the "UMMO group" is linked with the "LaRouche extremist movement in France." Source: "French investigators," none named. (3) During Desert One, the failed April 1980 attempt to rescue American hostages in Iran, a "disk resembling a UFO" was seen. "It was said to be a platform for nonlethal weapons, intended to paralyze or otherwise disable the Iranian guards." The "code word for that part of the operation, of which Richard Secord and Oliver North had been among the planners, was none other than *Snowbird*," a name that appears in recent UFO-conspiracy lore. Source: "some witnesses," none named.

Even as he complains of "eager believers [who] have fabricated fanciful explanations out of whole cloth," he

breathlessly spins theories out of what appears to be the same material. He enlists UMMO in the conspiracy, even as he mentions in passing the more prosaic findings of two Spanish investigators (actually named) who have uncovered evidence suggesting the supposedly extraterrestrial writings were forged by individuals (also named) associated with a Spanish contactee group. Poor Carl Meredith Allen (aka Carlos Miguel Allende) is resurrected from the saucerian boneyard, and we are to believe that Morris K. Jessup's suicide was in some way—here as elsewhere in the text Vallee is vague on details—connected with the conspiracy. In fact, from every available indication Jessup's suicide, like James McDonald's, had nothing to do with his UFO interests and everything to do with his personal problems. As for Allen, if Vallee had read Robert A. Goerman's article in the October 1980 issue of *Fate*—evidently he has never heard of it—we would have been spared this further exploitation of this sad character.

Vallee is brought to Norton Air Force Base to learn UFO "secrets" from two men whom even he recognizes as no more than naive saucer buffs. Yet when one tells of a desert meeting with a landed UFO some years earlier, Vallee cannot resist speculating that the occupants were American agents of the conspiracy. He does not think to ask why the U.S. government would go to the considerable trouble and expense of building an advanced aircraft and training pilots to act like space people simply to dazzle one obscure individual who would never publicize the experience.

I suppose that something like this *could* happen, but if we are to believe it did, Vallee will have to produce the relevant evidence. But evidence is the one element most conspicuously missing here—as, one might add, in all UFO-conspiracy literature. In the end, though he is sincerer and saner than most other current conspiracy theorists, he gives us no more reason to believe him than they do. Vallee has little to offer beyond unnamed informants and a ufological revisionism which offers us speculation and imagination in place of reason and substance. There is nothing remotely like the documentation a true investigative journalist would have nailed down before he wrote a book as loaded with bizarre and implausible allegations as Vallee's.

According to Vallee, UFO beliefs are so spiritually charged that they are actually changing society, and that is why the conspirators use them to manipulate us to some end or other about which Vallee is characteristically obscure. In fact, UFOs were trivialized and marginalized long ago, and outside ufology, which Vallee apparently has mistaken for the real world, they are visible, and even there not consistently so, mostly in popular culture, along with rap music, soap operas, supermarket tabloids, miniskirts, and other ephemera. As a vehicle for social transformation UFOs are just about the last thing any sane conspirator would choose.

A more interesting question is why and how a

phenomenon potentially so significant has come to appear to most people to be of no consequence whatever. Maybe that's where we'll uncover the conspiratorial machinations, if we are determined to find them. Other, less sinister explanations come to mind, however, and some can be found in less exciting but more intellectually fulfilling books and papers by sociologists of science.

Of course, if we were to follow the logic of Vallee's argument, why confine the conspiracy to the UFO era? If we don't let a dearth of evidence for a conspiracy stop us, there is no stopping us. What is to keep us from concluding, for example, that Richard Shaver was not a nut, as generally assumed, but the victim of a mind-control experiment which led him to believe he met alien creatures underneath the earth in the 1930s and 1940s? And what about 19th-Century Spiritualist mediums? Were they, too, victims of the conspiracy? After all, Spiritualism had a far more marked effect on Victorian culture than flying saucers have had on our own. A medium is even said to have encouraged President Lincoln to emancipate the slaves.

But if one has no compelling desire to drop into a black hole of unreason, one can but reflect that hoaxes, delusions, visions, and strange occurrences have always been a part of human experience, and since the UFO era has been lived by human beings, why should we expect it to be different? Why should not weird tales circulate in our time? In the absence of evidence, conspiracy theories of the sort Vallee proposes simply are unnecessary.

And yet, from time to time, Vallee touches on real issues. The Holloman Air Force Base affair, which concerns an apparently real film of what is supposed to be a meeting between government scientists and aliens, is a puzzle. So are the Bennewitz episode, the MJ-12 briefing document, and related matters. Vallee is surely correct, though he is hardly the first so to argue, that these amount to evidence both of a strange psychological-warfare experiment and (at least where Bennewitz is concerned) of egregious official misconduct. But to extrapolate a massive conspiracy from these small elements is simply to excuse oneself from the ranks of those who have a serious claim on our attention.

Throughout the text Vallee vents his spleen, as he did in his previous book *Confrontations*, on those ufologists who perversely insist on thinking for themselves even in the face of his repeated offers to do it for them. His books could as well be subtitled "Me Jacques; You Dumb." As always he displays minimal understanding of ufologists and their concerns. Sooner or later the alert reader will notice that hardly any of those unnamed "believers" and "amateurs" ever actually get *quoted*. Vallee prefers to set up and knock down straw arguments, always easier to do than to address the concerns of ufology's serious (as opposed to naive or cracked) researchers and theorists.

From all indications he still has not read Thomas E. Bullard on the patterns in abduction reports or Michael D. Swords on the scientific soundness of the extraterrestrial

hypothesis. No one familiar with *UFO Crash at Roswell* or *The Roswell Report* will feel Vallee has contributed anything to rational discourse on that subject. Vallee continues to ignore the many nontrivial criticisms of his approach I outlined in "The Thickets of Magonia" (*IUR*, January/February 1990). He has simply cranked up the volume as he declaims yet again what is less a scientific reading of the phenomenon than an occult one. Let us not forget that Magonia, the word Vallee made famous, translates as "Magicland."

Errors large and small litter the pages of *Revelations*, evincing Vallee's ignorance of any ufology but his own. Donald Keyhoe did not write *The UFO Conspiracy*, nor is Timothy Good the author of something called *Beyond Top Secret*. Benton Jamison is not "Benton Majison," and Detlev Bronk's first name was not "Detley." (For that matter, Leo Tolstoy's was not "Leon.") And whatever else page 216 would have you believe, CUFOS left Evanston, Illinois, years ago. Vallee's coverage of the crashed-disc question is a disaster. He has the Ubatuba incident occurring in 1933 or 1934 when it is supposed to have taken place in 1957. He places the Spitzbergen event in May 1947—contemporary published accounts put it in the early 1950s, though it is almost certainly a hoax—and Dorothy Kilgallen is incorrectly identified as the source of the rumor. The celebrated Texas/Mexico incident is set in a year and location different from those its proponents have assigned it.

One assumes, however, that no error lies behind Vallee's pretense that the *Journal of Scientific Exploration* is the "only refereed publication in the field" of ufology. First, *JSE* is not a ufological periodical, though it publishes occasional papers on the subject, and second, as Vallee is well aware as a former *JUFOS* board member, CUFOS' *Journal of UFO Studies* is ufology's only "refereed publication." This is Vallee's way of responding to his critics.

There is more to be said, but enough is enough. Let us close with Vallee's own words:

"Mysteries that linger without solution for such a long time are a powerful irritant to the mind; they tend to trigger wild speculation. When the very existence of the enigma is flatly denied by arrogant scientists who have not even taken the time to look at the data, when the government destroys or covers up the fact that its own employees have actually witnessed some of the best-documented sightings, it is natural for speculations to turn into paranoia, and for research to become derailed by fantastic delusions.

"It is at this point that the very people who could help us in our investigations, namely the UFO researchers themselves, become caught up in their own need to believe in the most bizarre theories, for which not a shred of real proof exists."

Sadly, Vallee has no idea that he has just described himself.—*Jerome Clark*

persons have mundane cover jobs and suffer from morale problems because—perhaps understandably—they do not take these cover jobs seriously; that there are several extraterrestrial bases throughout the world, including the United States; that our radar can track these craft occasionally but that a special “phenomenology” was devised to explain the appearance of such tracks to the low-level radar operators who therefore misidentify what they are seeing without realizing it, thereby unwittingly helping to cover up radar tracks; that we have worked with the Soviets on this for a number of years; that the insiders are concerned with the growing number of abduction reports since it now appears the aliens are “out of control” (whatever that means); and a number of other things I won’t go into for fear of identifying the source to his coworkers.

Aside from this source, it appears that Bill Moore and Jaime Shandera have the only other seemingly legitimate contacts into the deep inside. Some of what they have been told agrees with what S has said, but enough is different or unrelated that it appears Moore and Shandera have separate sources.

What is one to make of all this? Clearly if the Roswell retrieval really occurred, with pieces of unusual metal and bodies, much of the argumentation about the reality of a government cover-up is moot. All that is left is to rewrite UFO history in the light of the new information. If Roswell is not true, on the other hand, we are still left with many intriguing facts which point to a covert investigation.

In 1960 none other than Vice Adm. Hillenkoetter, who the EBD would have us believe was MJ-1, said the following (*New York Times*, February 28, 1960): “Behind the scenes, high ranking Air Force officers are soberly concerned about UFOs. But through official secrecy and ridicule, many citizens are led to believe that the unknown flying objects are nonsense. . . . [T]o hide the facts the Air Force has silenced its personnel.” Did Hillenkoetter know something he could not say directly? Perhaps he was also publicly acknowledging his distress at having to maintain the cover-up against his better judgment.

Is the silence about to end? Like a pressure cooker that has been heated for along time, things seem ready to explode. With the revelations of the past decade, the emergence of the abduction phenomenon, and the outbreak of dramatic radar/visual sightings in Europe, one is tempted to think that something has to give. In any case, the next year or two could be most interesting. ■

information on the ownership history of the parcel of land alleged to be the crash site. According to John Phillips, acting area manager, in a letter dated August 22, “There is no record of the land being owned by anyone other than the federal government.” Numerous pipelines cross the parcels, and the land is currently leased for grazing by a party not connected to the crash story.

The land-ownership history of the crash-site is somewhat murky. Clearly, someone needs to undertake a formal title search of the land if he or she wants to clear this matter up. (The cost of such a search could not be justified for this investigation, given the improbability of the crash’s occurrence. The lowest quoted price for the title search was \$300.) But from what is known so far, the claim that Harold Dunning transferred the land to the federal government during or soon after the retrieval operation is certainly untrue. If the crash site land was not transferred as Steinman has claimed, and this appears to be the case, a shadow of doubt is cast on the entire story as he presents it.

Fiction and fact

Neither the Scully book nor the Steinman book is persuasive. The critical information each presents is questionable. Everyone we contacted in Aztec, especially the older people who were adults in March of 1948, is certain that no crash ever took place. It is clear that the flying-saucer-crash story is part of Aztec’s folklore but not its history.

All the same the reality of the 1947 crash at Roswell seems by now almost a foregone conclusion. There is also some reason to suspect other crashes may have occurred. In this light Broman’s story about the way the FBI or Army Intelligence reacted to Silas Newton’s lecture on crashed saucers at the University of Denver is curious. The caller wanted to know if the lecture was believed, and when Broman told him it was not, the caller seemed satisfied. Perhaps that was because the cover-up—not of the nonexistent Aztec crash but of the real one at Roswell—was holding. ■

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